Across the Street – Game Design Document (MVP)

1. Game Overview

Across the Street is a first-person spy observation game set during a Cold War–inspired conflict. The player is an undercover American operative stationed in an apartment directly across from a low-profile foreign embassy. The core experience revolves around watching, interpreting subtle behaviors, and delivering intelligence without being discovered.

2. Core Design Pillars

- Observation over action
- Tension through uncertainty
- Minimal UI, strong atmosphere
- Player interpretation drives outcomes

3. Core Gameplay Loop (MVP)

- Observe the embassy through apartment windows
- Identify suspicious behavior or individuals
- Record or mark intel
- Deliver intel via hidden floorboard
- Receive consequences the next day

4. Setting & Narrative

The game takes place in a foreign city under political tension. The player is new to the operation and receives minimal guidance. Instructions arrive anonymously via notes slipped under the door. The player never meets their handler and is never told the full purpose of the mission.

5. Player Character

An American intelligence operative with limited field experience. Recently deployed and isolated. Motivation is unclear, reinforcing paranoia and uncertainty. The character never speaks; all identity is implied through actions.

6. Gameplay Systems (MVP Scope)

Observation System
• Two apartment windows
• Zoom and pan functionality
• Embassy windows with timed states (lights, silhouettes, meetings)

Target System
• One daily objective provided via note
• One correct target per day
• Multiple decoy behaviors

Intel Collection
• Mark windows or characters
• Preset notes instead of free text

Intel Delivery
• Hidden floorboard outside apartment
• One delivery opportunity per day

Consequences
• Correct intel builds trust
• Incorrect intel increases suspicion
• Embassy behavior subtly changes

7. User Interface (MVP)

- Binocular overlay
- Simple notebook or clipboard UI
- Daily instruction note UI
- Minimal interaction prompts

8. Minimum Viable Product Definition

The MVP consists of a single apartment, a single embassy building, and three in-game days. The player must successfully observe, interpret, and report information. Total playtime target: 15–30 minutes. If the core loop creates tension and uncertainty, the MVP is considered successful.

9. Development Priorities

- Window observation mechanics
- Embassy window state system
- Daily note generation
- Intel delivery interaction
- Basic consequence feedback